

Streamlining IT Procurement:

Automating Standard Laptop Orders with Flow Designer

An approved laptop request automatically creates a configuration task for the Hardware team – no manual hand-off needed.

Platform

ServiceNow (Workflow Studio / Flow Designer)

Scope

Flow build • Catalog assignment • End-to-end testing

Key artefacts

Flow: Standard laptop task | Item: Standard Laptop

SECTION 1

Project Overview

Problem statement

Ordering a standard laptop is a routine request, yet the configuration step that follows it is easy to forget or postpone. Because someone has to create and hand over that task manually, users wait longer than necessary and the IT team spends time on chasing work instead of doing it.

User story

As a member of the IT procurement team, I want configuration tasks for standard laptops to be created and routed to the hardware team on their own, so that each laptop is set up as soon as it arrives and nobody has to intervene by hand.

Objectives

#	Objective	How this project delivers it
1	Give users timely laptop configuration	A catalog task exists the moment the request is approved
2	Cut manual effort and errors	Task creation and assignment are done by the flow, not a person
3	Use IT staff better	Work lands directly in the Hardware group's queue
4	Raise procurement efficiency	One repeatable, automated path for every standard laptop order

Solution at a glance

A Flow Designer flow named **Standard laptop task** listens for Service Catalog requests. When a Standard Laptop is ordered, the flow uses the **Create Catalog Task** action to open a task on the requested item, fill in its descriptions, and assign it to the **Hardware** group. The flow is then attached to the Standard Laptop catalog item so every new order triggers it.

Milestone	What you will do	Result
1 – Build the flow	Create, configure, save and activate the flow	Active flow: Standard laptop task
2 – Attach the flow	Link the flow to the Standard Laptop item	Orders start the flow automatically
3 – Test end to end	Order a laptop, approve it, inspect the task	Catalog task created for Hardware

Before you begin

- Access to a ServiceNow instance with an administrator account (needed for Flow Designer and catalog maintenance).
- The **Standard Laptop** catalog item in the Hardware category (it ships with the demo data, Lenovo Carbon x1).
- A **Hardware** assignment group in the instance.

MILESTONE 1

Build the Flow

Activity 1 – Create a flow that generates a catalog task, sets its short description, and assigns it to the Hardware group once the request is approved.

1 Open Flow Designer

- Sign in to your ServiceNow instance.
- Click **All** in the top navigation bar and type **flow designer** in the filter box.
- Under **Process Automation**, choose **Flow Designer**. It opens in a new tab (Workflow Studio).

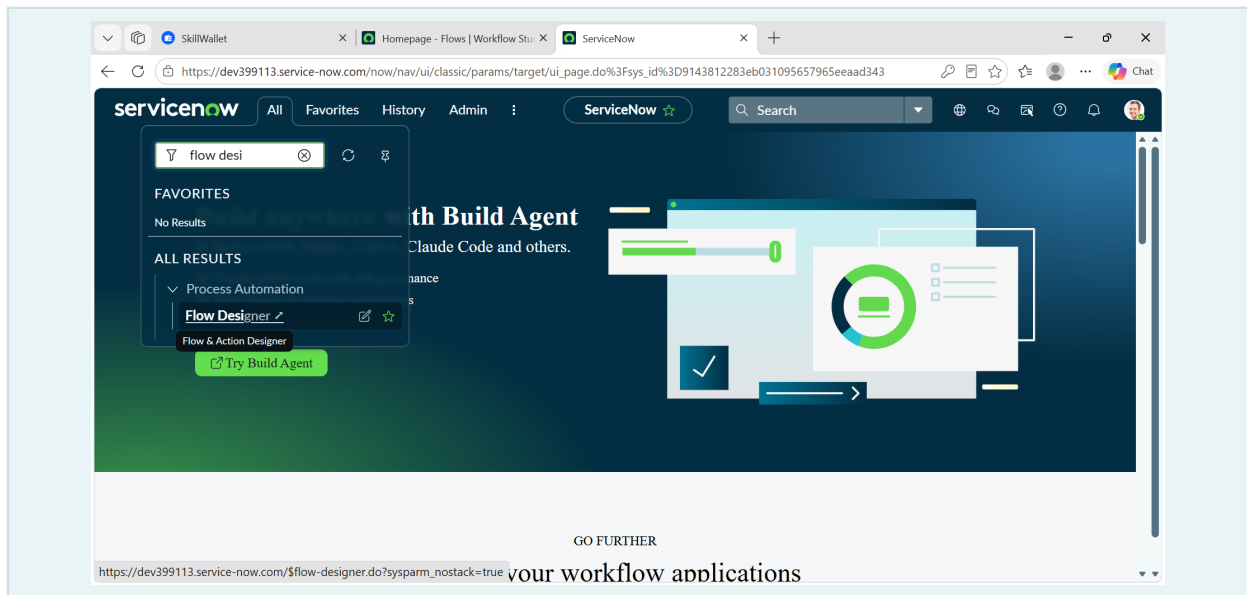


Figure 1 – Finding Flow Designer under Process Automation

2 Start a new flow

- Workflow Studio opens on the **Homepage** with the **Flows** list selected.
- Click the **New** button at the top right of the list.
- From the dropdown choose **Flow**.

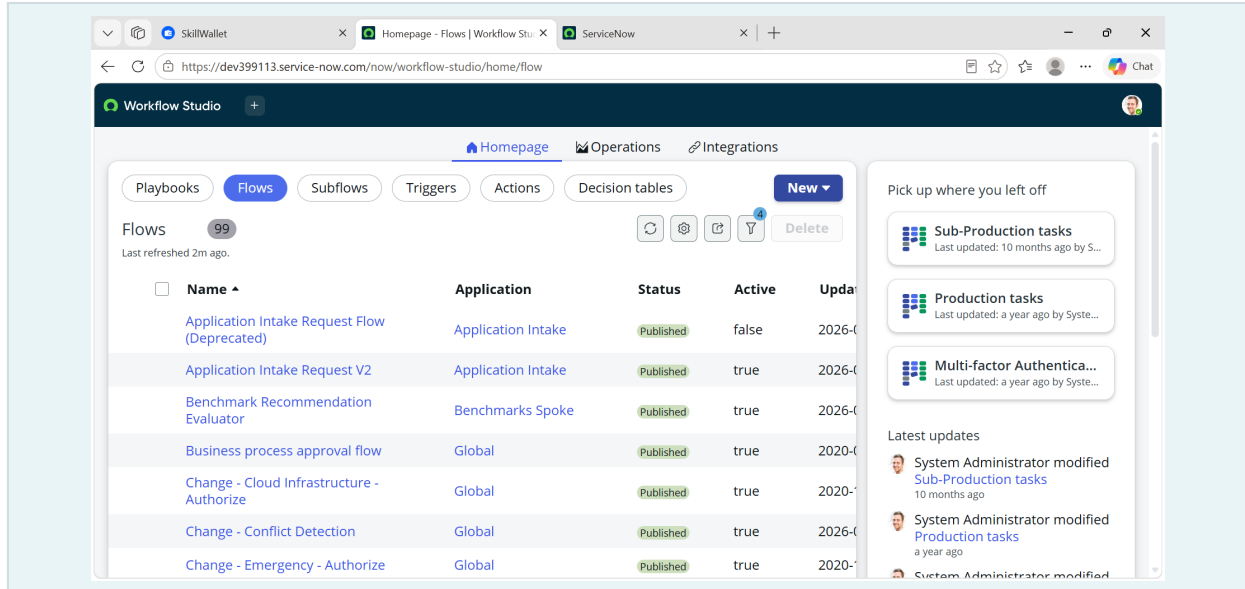


Figure 2 – The Flows list in Workflow Studio

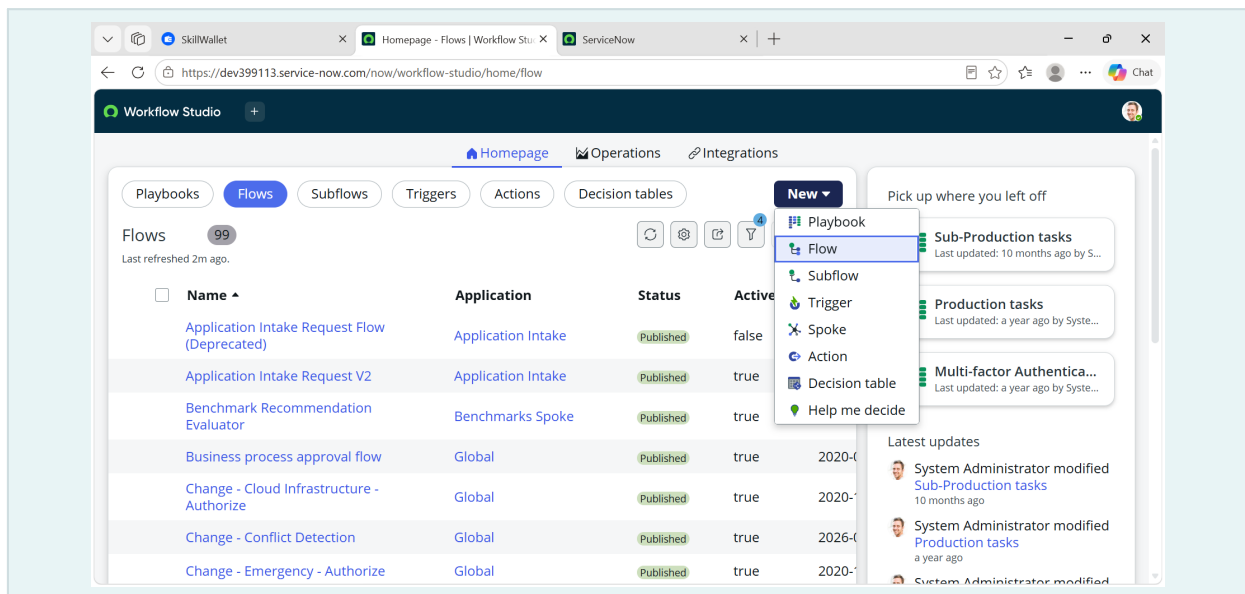


Figure 3 – New menu with the Flow option

3 Set the flow properties

- **Flow name:** Standard laptop task
- **Application:** Global
- **Run as:** System user (so the flow does not depend on the ordering user's permissions).
- Leave the other fields as they are, then click **Build flow**.

Figure 4 – Flow properties form

NOTE Older UI versions label this final button **Submit**. The result is the same: the empty flow canvas opens.

4 Add the Service Catalog trigger

- In the **Trigger** section, click to add a trigger.
- Open the trigger dropdown, search for **Service Catalog**, and select it.
- Click **Done**. The Data panel on the right now offers *Requested Item Record*, which the next step needs.

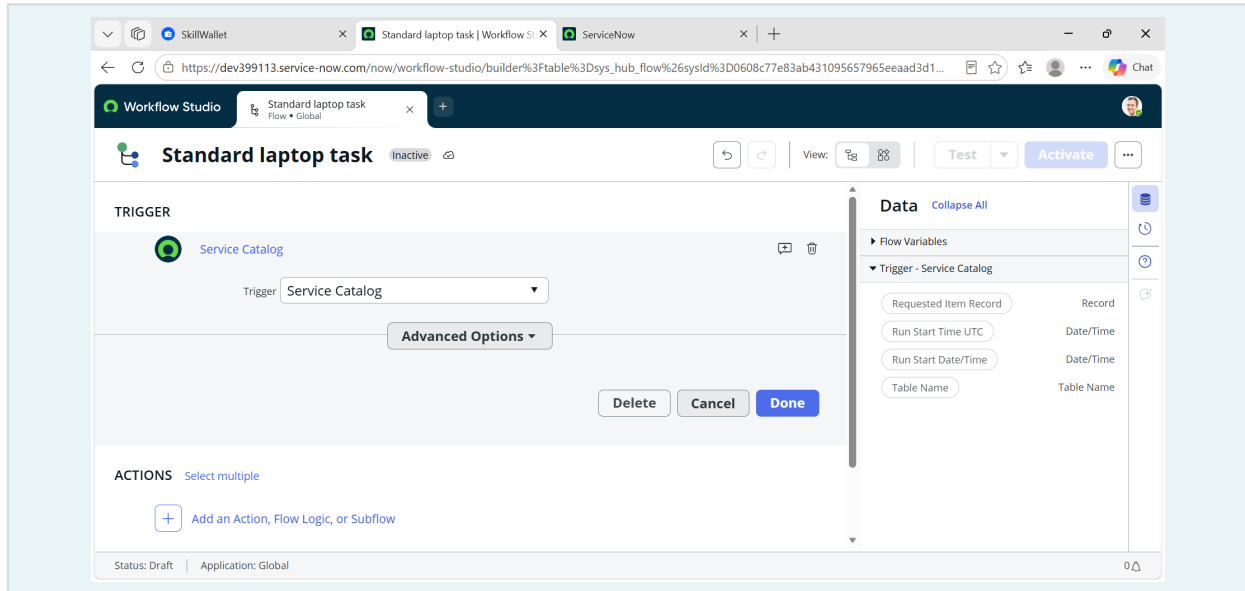


Figure 5 – Trigger set to Service Catalog

5 Add the Create Catalog Task action

- Under **Actions**, click **Add an Action, Flow Logic, or Subflow**.
- Choose **Action** and type **Create Catalog Task** in the search box.
- Pick **Create Catalog Task** from the **ServiceNow Core** spoke.

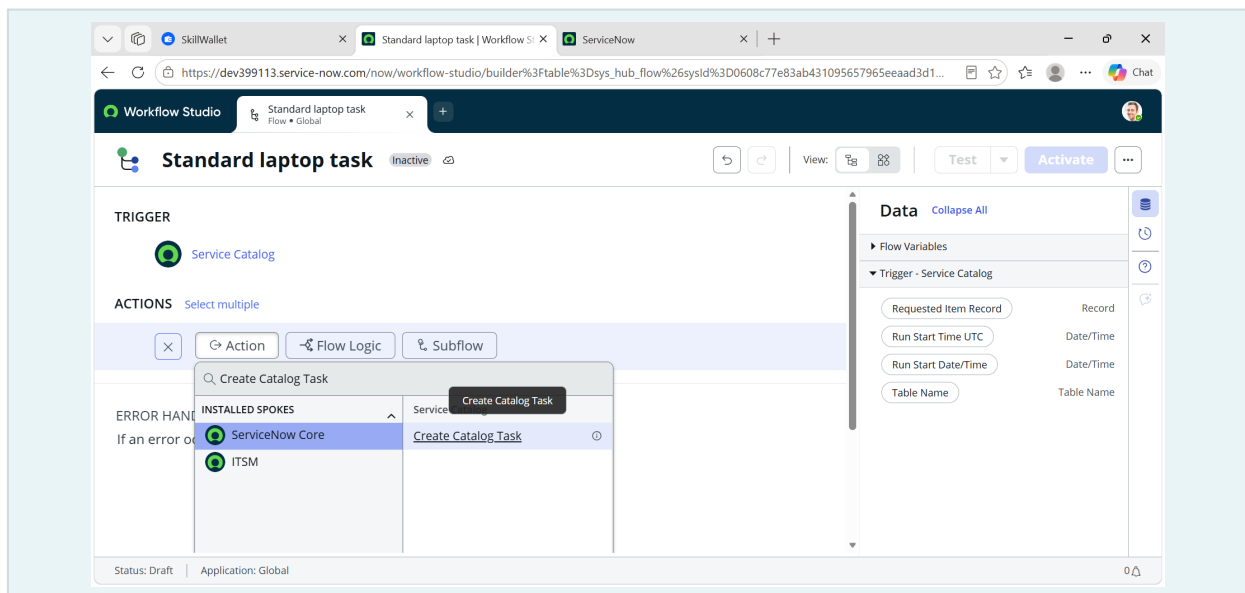


Figure 6 – Searching for the Create Catalog Task action

6 Fill in the action inputs

- **Requested Item:** drag *Requested Item Record* from the Trigger section of the Data panel into this field. **Table Name** fills itself with *Catalog Task [sc_task]*.
- **Short Description:** Laptop need to Configured
- Click **Add field value** three times and set: **Description** = Laptop need to Configured; **Assignment group** = Hardware; **Approval** = Approved.
- Keep **Wait** ticked and leave all other inputs at their defaults, then click **Done**.

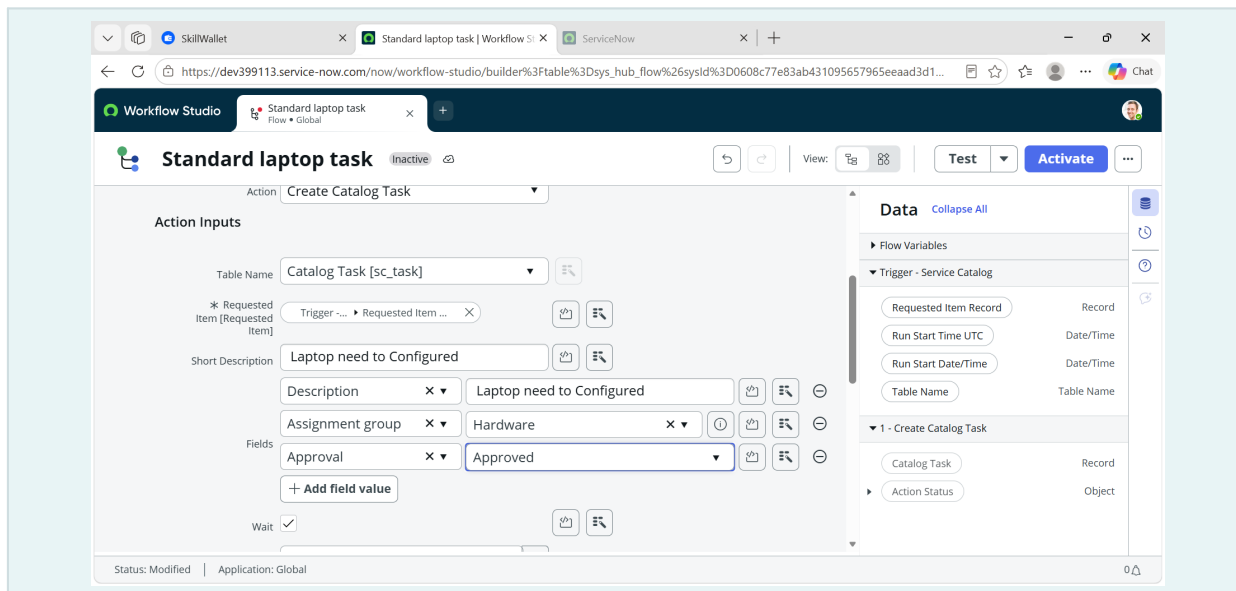


Figure 7 – Completed Create Catalog Task inputs

7 Save and activate the flow

- Click **Save** to store your work.
- Click **Activate** at the top right.
- When asked *Are you sure you want to activate the flow?*, click **Activate** again. The status badge changes from Inactive to Active.

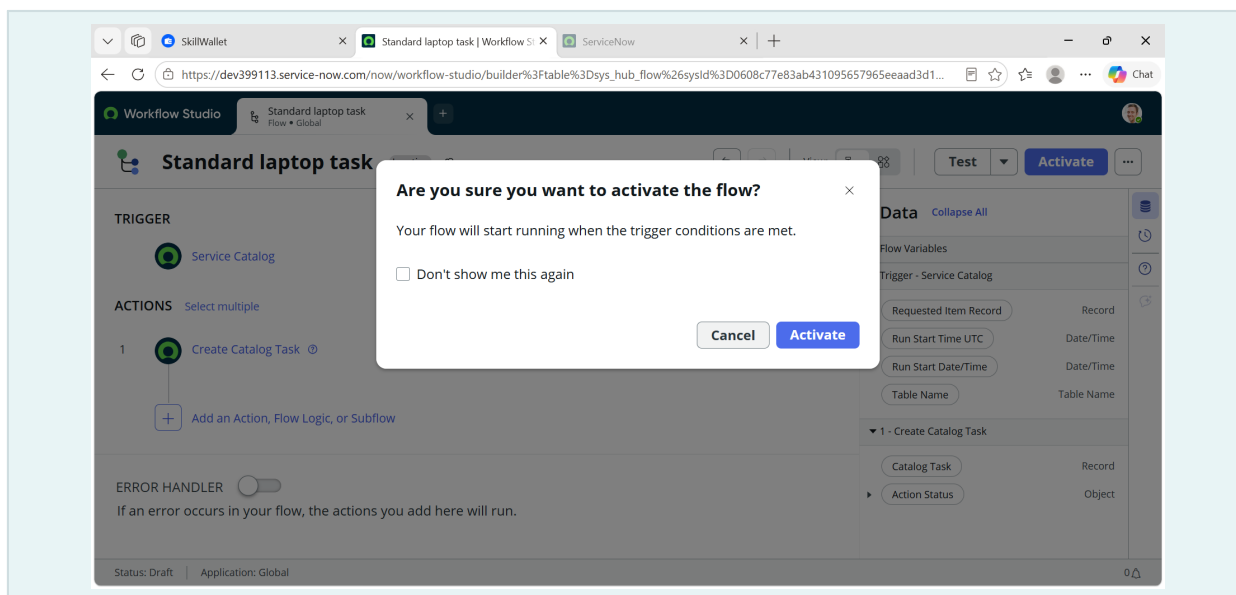


Figure 8 – Activation confirmation dialog

MILESTONE 2

Attach the Flow to the Catalog Item

Activity 1 – Tell ServiceNow to run the new flow whenever the Standard Laptop item is ordered.

1 Open Maintain Items

- Go back to the main ServiceNow tab and click **All**.
- Type **maintain items** in the filter box.
- Select **Service Catalog Catalog Definitions Maintain Items**.

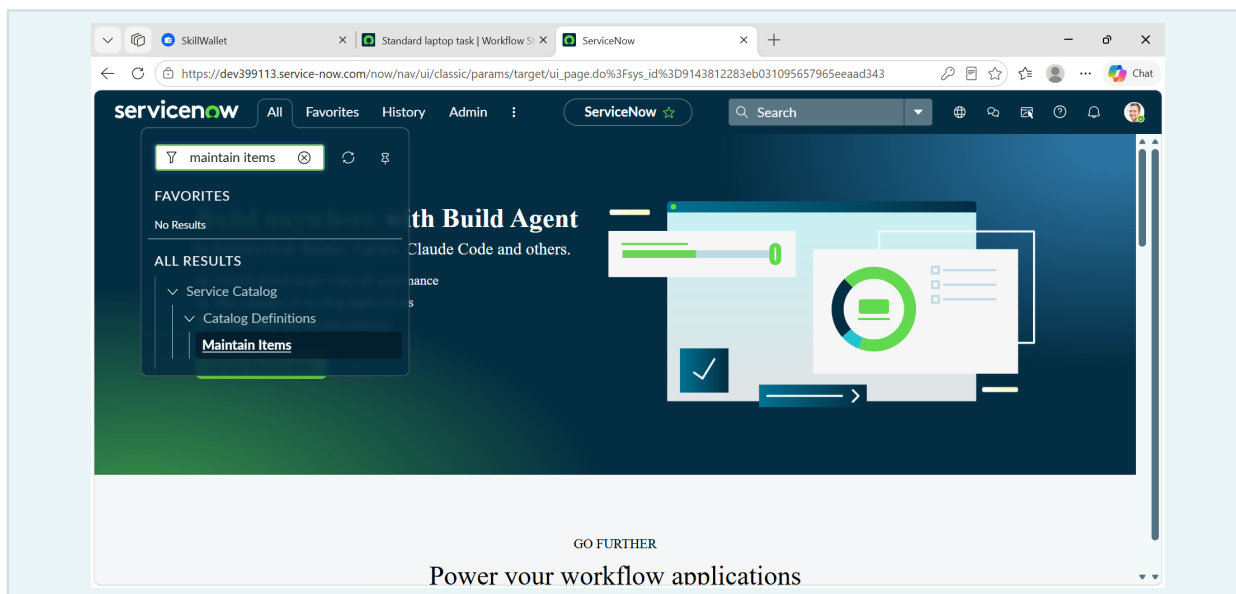


Figure 9 – Navigating to Maintain Items

2 Find the Standard Laptop record

- In the Name column search box, type **Standard Laptop** and press Enter.
- Open the **Standard Laptop** row (Lenovo – Carbon x1, category Hardware, price \$1,100.00).

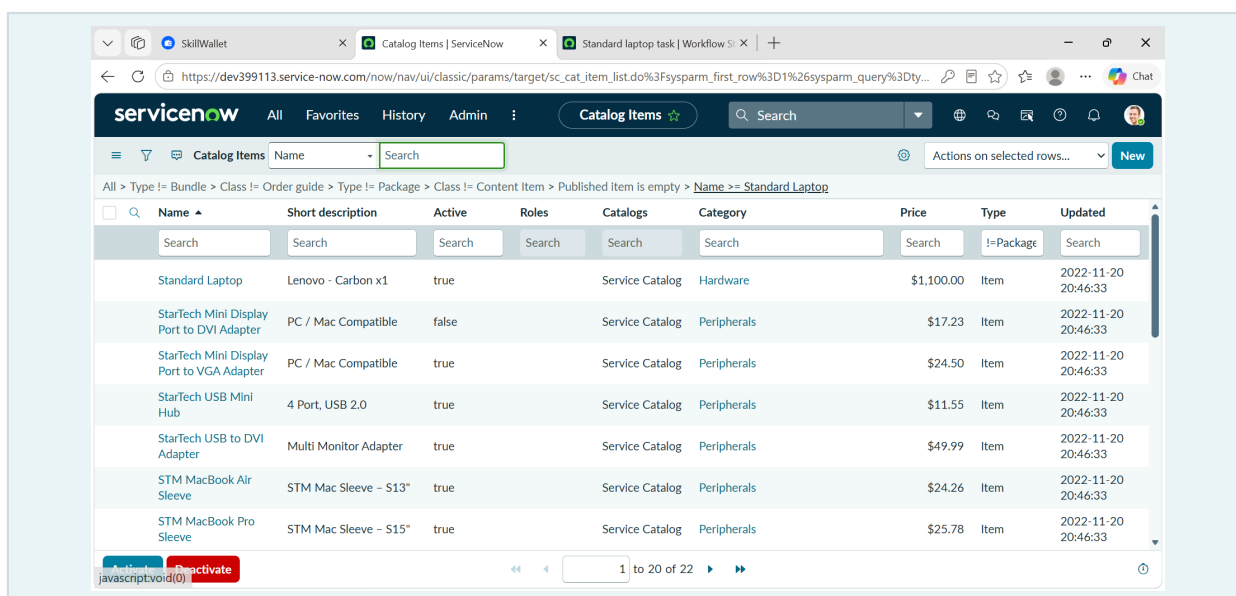


Figure 10 – Standard Laptop in the Catalog Items list

3 Set the process engine

- On the item form, open the **Process Engine** tab.
- Only one engine can be active. Clear anything already in **Workflow** or **Execution Plan**.
- In the **Flow** field, select **Standard laptop task**.
- Save with **Update** (or right-click the form header and choose Save).

The screenshot shows the ServiceNow interface for editing a catalog item named 'Standard Laptop'. The 'Process Engine' tab is selected, displaying a message: 'Select the appropriate process engine for the catalog item. Only one engine can be selected.' Below this message, the 'Flow' field is set to 'Standard laptop task' and the 'Workflow' field is empty. The top navigation bar includes 'Catalog Item - Standard Laptop' and buttons for 'Copy', 'Try It', 'Update', 'Edit in Catalog Builder', and 'Delete'. The left sidebar shows the item details, and the right sidebar shows the 'Active' checkbox checked and the 'Fulfillment automation level' set to 'Unspecified'.

Figure 11 – Flow field set to Standard laptop task

MILESTONE 3

Order, Approve and Verify

Activity 1 – Place a laptop order, approve it, and confirm that the flow created the configuration task.

1 Open the Service Catalog

- Click **All** and type **service catalog**.
- Choose **Self-Service Service Catalog**.

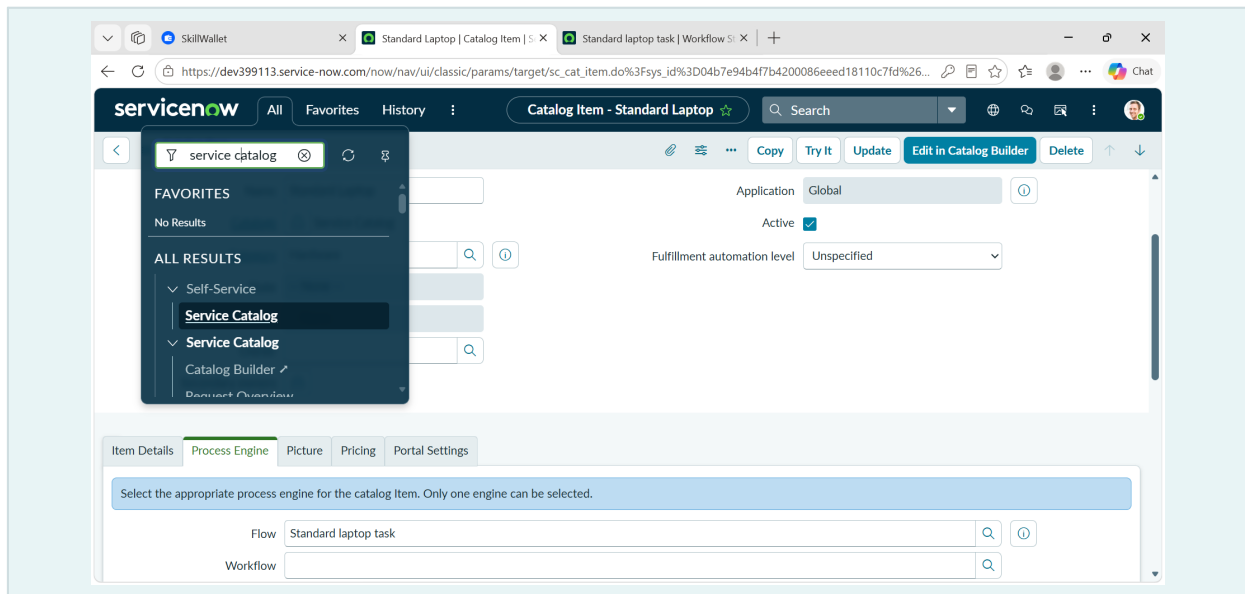


Figure 12 – Opening the Service Catalog from the navigator

2 Go to Hardware and open Standard Laptop

- On the catalog home page click the **Hardware** category.
- Find **Standard Laptop** in the list (it also appears under Top Requests) and open it.

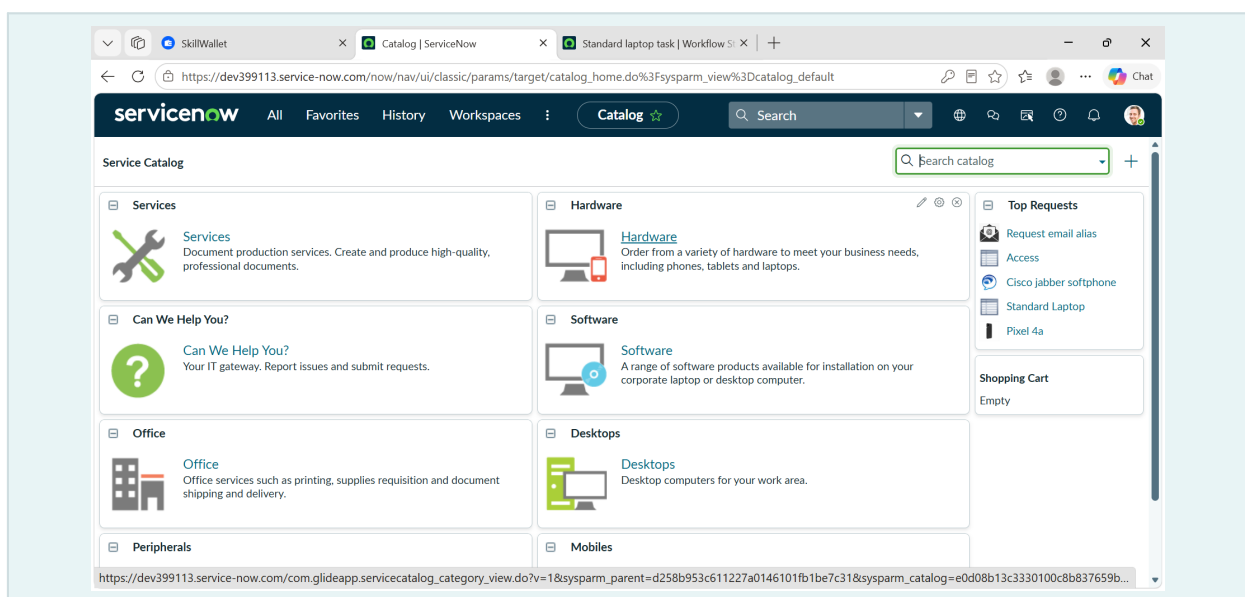


Figure 13 – Service Catalog home with the Hardware category

3 Place the order

- Review the item details: Lenovo Carbon x1, Intel Core i5, 512 GB SSD, backlit keyboard.
- Leave quantity at 1; optional software can stay unticked.
- Click **Order Now**.

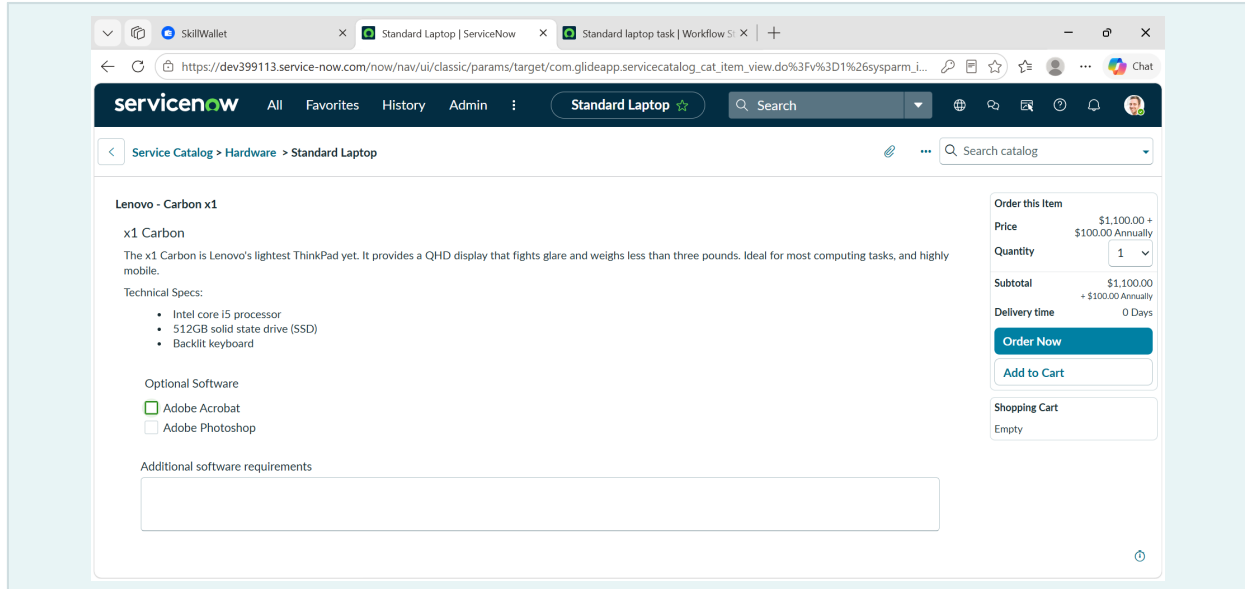


Figure 14 – Standard Laptop item page

4 Note the request number

- The Order Status page confirms *Thank you, your request has been submitted.*
- Click the request number (here **REQ0010001**) to open the request record.

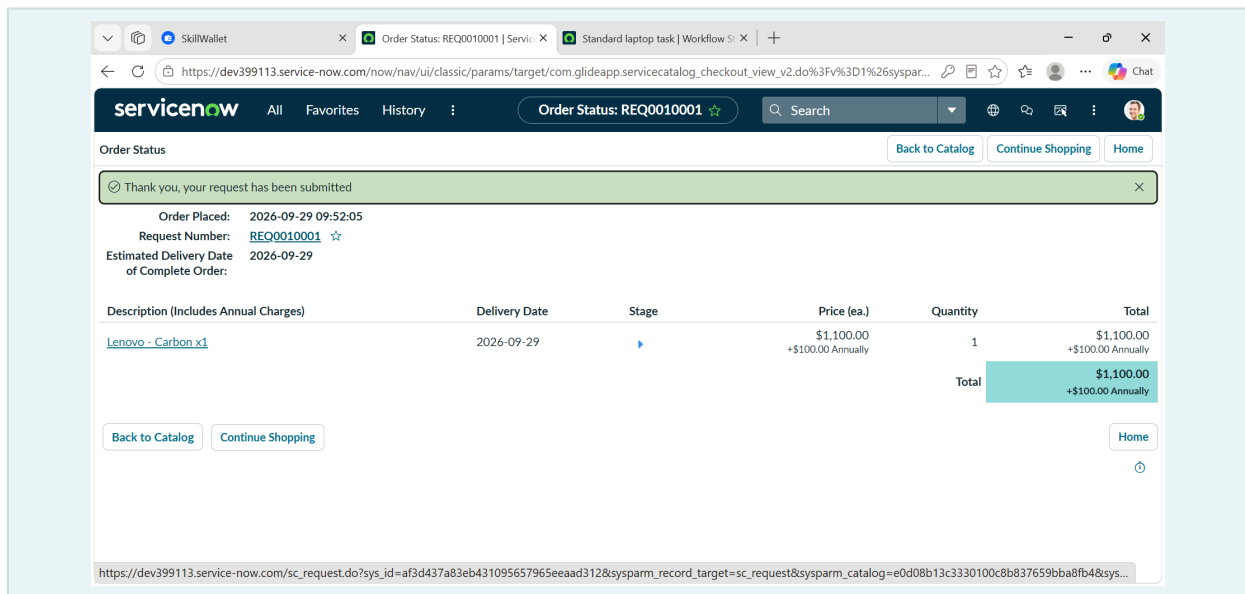


Figure 15 – Order status showing REQ0010001

5 Approve the request

- Scroll down the request and open the **Approvers** tab.
- The approval row shows state *Requested* for the approver (Eric Schroeder in this instance).
- Right-click the row and choose **Approve** – not Reject.

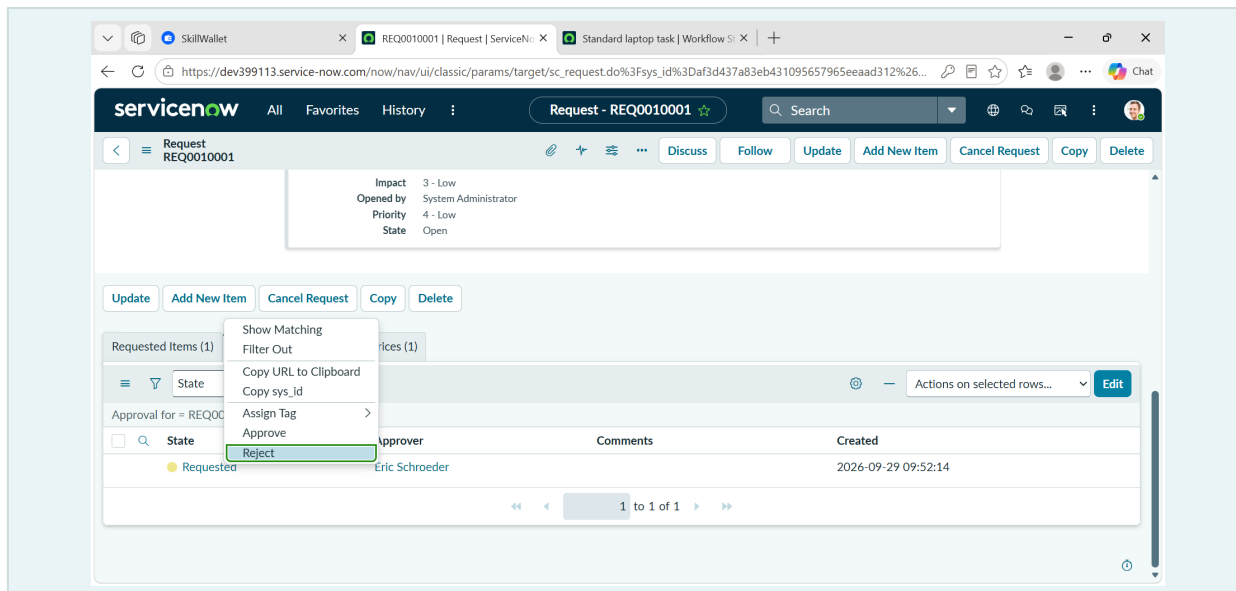


Figure 16 – Right-click menu on the approval record

NOTE Approve the request before checking for tasks. In this flow the catalog task is created with its approval already set to Approved.

6 Open the requested item

- Switch to the **Requested Items** tab.
- Open the requested item record (**RITM0010001**, Standard Laptop, quantity 1).

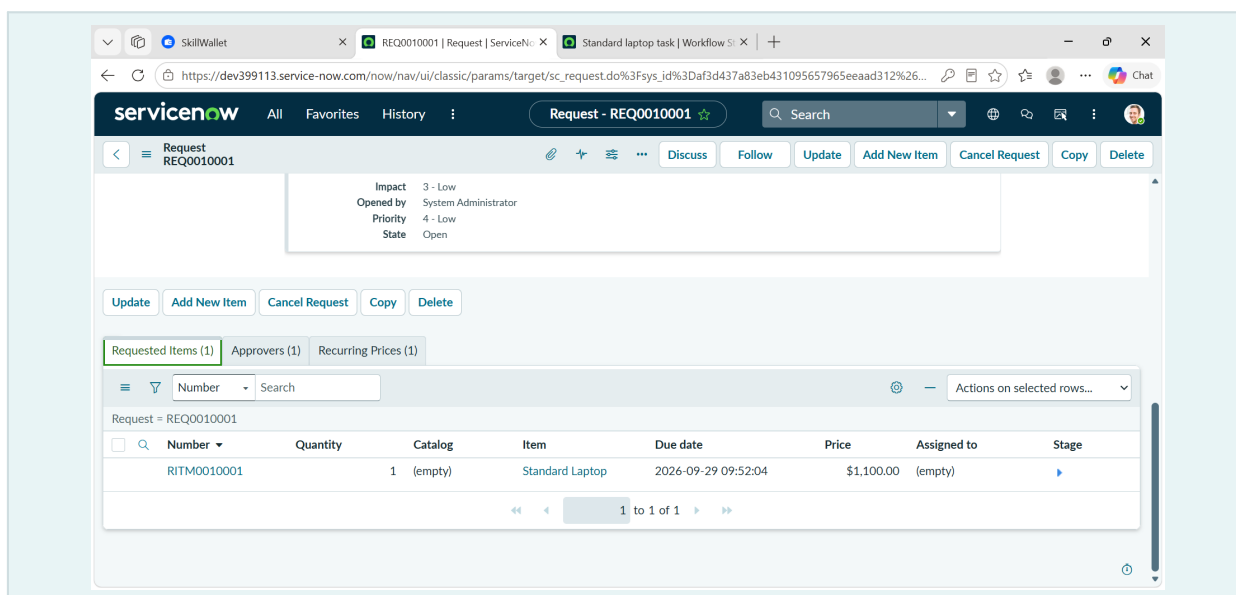


Figure 17 – Requested item RITM0010001

7 Verify the catalog task

- On the requested item, scroll to the **Catalog Tasks** related list.
- A task is listed there with the assignment group **Hardware**. Open it (**SCTASK0010001**).
- Check that Short description and Description read *Laptop need to Configured*, Approval is **Approved**, and Request item is RITM0010001.

The screenshot displays the ServiceNow Catalog Task form for SCTASK0010001. The form is titled "Catalog Task - SCTASK0010001" and includes a search bar and navigation links (Discuss, Follow, Update, Close Task, Delete). The form fields are organized into two columns. The left column contains: Number (SCTASK0010001), Assigned to (searchable), Configuration Item (searchable), Active (checked), Short description (Laptop need to Configured), Description (Laptop need to Configured), and Comments (Customer visible). The right column contains: Approval (Approved), Priority (4 - Low), State (Open), Request Item (RITM0010001), and Requested for (System Administrator). At the bottom, there is a "Work notes" section with a "Post" button. The footer shows "Activities: 1" and "Field changes • 2026-09-29 09:53:48".

Figure 18 – Catalog task SCTASK0010001 created by the flow

SECTION 5

Test Results and Conclusion

Verification summary

Check	Expected	Observed
Flow status	Standard laptop task is Active	Activation confirmed (Fig. 8)
Item linkage	Flow field on Standard Laptop = Standard laptop task	Set on Process Engine tab (Fig. 11)
Order placed	A request is created	REQ0010001 submitted (Fig. 15)
Approval	Approver can approve the request	Approval row available (Fig. 16)
Requested item	RITM created for the laptop	RITM0010001 (Fig. 17)
Catalog task	Task with the configured text, Approved, for Hardware	SCTASK0010001 (Fig. 18)

Configuration reference

Setting	Value
Flow name	Standard laptop task (Global, run as System user)
Trigger	Service Catalog
Action	Create Catalog Task (ServiceNow Core)
Short description / Description	Laptop need to Configured
Assignment group	Hardware
Approval	Approved
Catalog item	Standard Laptop (Hardware) Process Engine Flow

Conclusion

Automating the standard laptop process with Flow Designer removes a manual hand-off that used to be easy to miss. Each order now produces a configuration task that reaches the Hardware team straight away, so laptops can be prepared on arrival, users wait less, and the IT department spends its time on the work itself rather than on creating and routing tasks.

Possible next steps

- Set the task Assigned to field or add an SLA so the work has a clear owner and deadline.
- Extend the same pattern to other standard hardware items such as monitors or docking stations.